

Questions and Answers with Professor Lisa Randall, Class of 1980



Professor Lisa Randall researches theoretical particle physics and cosmology at Harvard University, where she is the Frank B. Baird, Jr. Professor of Science on the physics faculty. She graduated from Stuyvesant High School in 1980, where she contributed to the Math Team and Math Survey. Currently a member of the American Academy of Arts and Sciences, the National Academy of Sciences, and the American Philosophical Society, she is the recipient of many awards and honorary degrees. Professor Randall was included in 2007's list of TIME Magazine's "100 Most Influential People" and was among Esquire magazine's "75 Most Influential People of the 21st Century." Professor Randall's two books, Warped Passages (2005) and Knocking on Heaven's Door (2011) are New York Times bestsellers and are featured on their lists of 100 Notable Books. She is also known for her contributions to the Randall-Sundrum model and for her research in elementary particles and fundamental forces (Harper Collins Publishers).

Professor Randall's answers are taken from an e-mail interview conducted by Josephine Lee and have been edited for clarity.

1) Why do you enjoy physics so much?

I like making connections to apparently disparate phenomena. It is very satisfying. I also like problem solving. And of course the opportunity to think about the world.

2) Who or what inspired your passion for math/science and physics in particular?

I always liked math. Of course my first real introduction to physics was in high school, and Mr. Baumel was a great teacher! Solving physics problems and learning how things operate was also very satisfying.

3) What do you remember about contributing to *Math Survey*? How did it impact you?

I remember the Math Team much more. It impacted me by making me wake up insanely early! (I had an hour and twenty minute commute each way). But with both Math Team and *Math Survey*, I loved the opportunity to be with such incredibly smart students.

4) Were there any specific teachers, people, or memories of Stuyvesant that have had a significant impact on you? Looking back, what would you tell your 16-year-old self?

I guess I already answered that... But mostly I also remembered the celebration of quirkiness. In Fresh Meadows, where I grew up, you were condemned for being different. In Stuyvesant, the creative oddballs were admired. Oddly enough, I would probably tell myself to take more time off. You're only a kid once!

5) What obstacles have you overcome as a woman in physics? How did you overcome them?

Seriously, for women I think there are obstacles every day. We are so used to them we ignore them or just suppress them a lot of the time. But I might even ask for directions or a question about physics, and the guy we talk to will inevitably answer the guy standing next to me. You have to shout a little louder to be heard. And then you are a little bit resented for doing that. There is no easy solution.

Having said that, you do good work and focus on what's important, and a lot of people are a lot more normal. But there are always people who will give you a hard time. You just have to ignore them or prove them wrong!

6) What advice would you give to aspiring women going in STEM? Anyone going into STEM?

Just do your best. Keep your eye on the prize. It's the same advice I would give to aspiring men by the way!

7) What are the biggest factors that have helped you be successful? What are your success habits?

I like to think I had some talent, and I also worked hard. I am very undisciplined, oddly enough. But when I get absorbed I like to focus a lot!

8) What are your favorite parts about being a researcher? An author? A professor?

I love problem solving. I like when people respond well to what I share with them and how I do it and when people admire my writing. But I also like the positive effects it has, such as inspiring people. Students can be amazing.

9) What are your least favorite/hardest parts about being a researcher? An author? A professor?

The problem is doing all three. I just don't have enough time. Any one of these things can take all your attention.

10) You have won numerous awards, contributed to the Randall–Sundrum model, and written multiple books that have been on the New York Times 100 Notable Books list, among several other incredible accomplishments. What would you consider to be your greatest accomplishment? Why?

Staying true to myself through it all. You have to remember what you think is important.